2.1 The importance of semantic HTML

Demonstrating a strong understanding of HTML is a key advantage in any frontend interview, regardless of the web framework being used. HTML forms the foundation of web development, providing the structure and semantics that browsers rely on to render content accurately and accessibly. Interviewers look for candidates who can clearly explain how semantic elements and proper document hierarchy improve maintainability, accessibility, and cross-browser compatibility, showing your ability to build scalable applications.

Here are some example interview questions that can be used to assess a candidate’s knowledge of semantic HTML.

- Initial question: "What is semantic HTML and why is it important?"
- Follow-up question: "Give examples of semantic HTML tags and explain their typical use cases."
- Probing question: "How does semantic HTML impact accessibility and SEO (Search Engine Optimization)?"

Interviewers may not ask the question directly. Instead, they can assess understanding of semantic elements through practical coding exercises. This happened to Jane in a React interview. She was asked to implement a React component, shown in figure 2.1. The component should include a header with the title "My Favorite Article" and a subtitle of the selected article. The main content should include the article's sections, each with a section heading and subsections with headings and paragraphs. Finally, the component should include a footer with copyright information.

Figure 2.1 A web page displaying a favorite article with a title, subtitle, and subsections.